

‘O, YOWR LOUELY WORDYS’: LATIN AND LATINATE DICTION IN *MANKIND*

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The importance of the status of language in *Mankind* has long been recognised.¹ The play itself contains obvious clues regarding the importance of proper language: Mercy warns the Vices ‘Thys ydyll language 3e xall repent.’ (147), wonders ‘How may yt be excusyde before þe Justyce of all | When for euery ydyll worde we muste 3elde a reson?’ (172-7), and he admonishes Mankind ‘Be ware of New Gyse, Nowadays, and Nought. | Nyse [*foolish*] in þer aray, in language þei be large [*licentious*]’ (294-5).² There also are references to writing: Mankind sits down to ‘tytyll [*write down*] in þis papyr’ (315) and Nought, also known as ‘owr Tulli’ (692), keeps record during the mock court scene. It is no coincidence that the devil in this play is Titivillus who was supposed to record verbal sins such as idle chatter in church and careless declamation of the liturgy. Janette Dillon in particular has analysed the role of Latin and the vernacular in *Mankind* in relation to the debates, current in the fifteenth century, about the use of Latin and the vernacular in contemporary religious life.³ Although there is little direct evidence for Lollard activity in East Anglia between the 1430s and the 1480s there was a ‘continuing interest in anti-Wycliffite propaganda’ which seems to indicate that the debate over language choice was on-going.⁴ Dillon, in fact, does refer to two East Anglian heresy trials (in 1457 and 1467) around the time *Mankind* was probably composed and argues that the ‘the author may have found himself in sympathy with the Lollard insistence on the need to use English in order to reach the widest audience’.⁵ This potential Lollard slant in the play’s attitude to language also comes to the fore in her summary of Mercy’s diction throughout the play:

After the extreme Latinity of his opening speech, he finds plainer speech in the middle of the play, and returns in his final speech to a more Latinate mode, but one still much less exaggerated than that of his opening speech ... This return to Latinity (however simplified) may reflect self-censorship of dangerous times, but is perhaps more likely to represent a plea for a middle way among preachers which would avoid the exclusive excesses of Latinity and admit the

necessity of some plain English without incurring the suspicion of heresy.⁶

This argument that the use of Latin and Latinate diction in *Mankind* represents a Lollard anti-Latin sentiment is at first sight attractive. After all, the modern reader or spectator often experiences the Vices' mock Latin as more memorable and more entertaining than the aureate style of Mercy and the virtuous Mankind. On the other hand, the only surviving copy of the play was probably copied by, and certainly in the possession of, a monk named Hyngham who also (wrote and) owned a copy of *Wisdom*.⁷ This is noteworthy for three reasons. Firstly, it is perhaps unlikely, though by no means impossible, that a monk would (copy and) own a text with Lollard overtones. Secondly, Hyngham was a monk at Bury St Edmonds, the monastery of John Lydgate (died c.1450), who coined both the adjective *aureat* and the aureate style. So it seems entirely plausible that Hyngham (and/or the playwright and other readers or spectators of *Mankind*) would have appreciated the aureate, Lydgatean diction of the virtuous characters.⁸ Norton-Smith's analysis of Lydgate's aureate style stresses the importance of the importation of Latin nouns and adjectives from the liturgy or the Vulgate for 'artistic, rhetorical ends', which fits the use of Latinate diction by Mankind and Mercy in the play very well.⁹ Thirdly, Hyngham (copied and) owned *Wisdom* too, which also uses some Latinate diction and Latin, e.g. 'Off yowr name þe hye felycyte | No creature knowyt full exposycyon' (25–6) and *Sapientia specialior est sole* ('Wisdom is more beautiful than the sun', 27), without a hint that such language might be controversial.¹⁰ Although *Wisdom* is not as aureate or Latinate as *Mankind* it seems plausible that Hyngham at least did not object to, and possibly even enjoyed, such language. Moreover, it is likely that any medieval audience would have been more familiar with, and consequently have felt far more at ease with, Latin and the aureate style than most modern ones.¹¹ I do not intend to assess the whole corpus of East Anglian drama but it is indeed evident that Latinate, aureate diction and Latin are frequently used, often by virtuous characters in a perfectly *bona fide* way. For instance, in the N.Town Play Ysaia claims to be 'Replett with Godys grett influens' (N.Town 7: 2) and says 'by spyryte of prophecie' (N.Town 7: 3) *quod virgo concipiet | Et pariet filium, nomen Emanuel* ('that a virgin shall conceive and bear a son, named Emanuel', N.Town 7: 9–10).¹² There is extensive use of Latin by Mary, translated by Elizabeth, in 'The Visit to Elizabeth' (N.Town 13) and Jesus opens 'The Woman Taken in Adultery' with *Nolo mortem peccatoris* ('I desire not the

death of the wicked'). | Man, for þi synne take repentaunce' (N.Town 24.1–2). A good example of aureate language in this cycle is Contemplacio's opening stanza:

Cryst conserve þis congregacyon
 Fro perellys past, present, and future,
 And þe personys here pleand, þat þe pronunciacyon
 Of here sentens to be sayd mote be sad and sure;
 And þat non oblocucyon [*error in delivery*] make þis matere obscure,
 But it may profite and plese eche persone present
 From þe gynnyng to þe endyng so to endure,
 þat Cryst and every creature with þe conceyte [*concept, plan*] be content.
 N.Town 8: 1–8

Negative characters do in fact also use elaborate language with polysyllabic words of ultimately Latin origin, as in Satan's 'Byholde þe dyvercyte of my dysgysyd varyauns [*inconstancy, duplicity*]' (N.Town 26: 65), but the (uncontested) examples of such language by virtuous characters shows that this language in itself was considered admirable, presumably by playwright and audience alike. We find a similar situation in the *Digby Mary Magdalen* and the *Croxton Play of the Sacrament*. In fact, in these plays the aureate language used by negative characters can have an obvious comic effect, yet as good characters also use it, this seems to undermine criticism of aureate language *per se* which such comedy might imply. Aureate language appears merely to enhance the comedy of a negative character, and it is the incongruity of such a character using such language, rather than Latinate language itself, which creates the comedy. For instance, in the *Digby Mary Magdalen* there seems to be some parody of high-style language in Mary Magdalen's incongruous line 'Your debonarius [*courteous*] obedyans ravyssyt me to trankquilyte!' (447).¹³ This line does contain linguistically comic elements with the oxymoron of *ravyssyt* and *trankquilyte* as well as the elsewhere unrecorded form *debonarius*.¹⁴ However, it seems to me that the audience is meant to laugh at Mary Magdalen's pretentiousness, as revealed in her inability to grasp such aureate language, rather than the aureate style itself — after all, if she had used Latinate words correctly, her line would lose its comic appeal. Her pretence to high-style diction is ridiculous, not the high-style diction itself. In fact, in the play the virtuous characters also use this kind of language without any obvious sense of irony, e.g. Jesus' 'And þe bemys of grace xal byn illumynous' (623) and Mary Magdalen's 'O Jhesu, þi mellyfous name |

Mott be worcheppyd wyth reverens!' (1446–7). The Latin of virtuous characters can, moreover, have very potent effects in this play. Immediately after Jesus addresses Mary Magdalen with 'Wherfor I sey to þe, *Vade in pace*' ('go in peace', 691), there was some dramatic stage action, as the directions reveal: 'Wyth þis word sevyn dyllys [*devils*] xall dewoyde from þe woman and the Bad Angyll entyr into hell wyth thondyr'. Later on in the play, Mary Magdalen's quotation of the psalms in Latin has a similar effect (1446–7 and following stage directions). The powerful status of Latin is not undermined by the mock Latin of the pagan priest's boy; instead, the inefficacy of any other form of religious discourse in the mouths of the inept is highlighted by this delightful passage.¹⁵ In the *Croxton Play of the Sacrament*, we also find aureate, Latinate language used by very good characters, for instance, Jhesus, who also uses Latin (e.g. 682–9), and by less positive characters, for instance, Master Brundyche (521–7).¹⁶ Although the latter instance has a possible comedic element with the long rhyme sequence on *-cyon* (*congregacyon*, *negacyon*, *certifyfacyon*, *proclamacion*, *pausacyon*, and *declaracion*; 521–6), we find a similar, though shorter, extended rhyme on *-aunce* (*chaunce*, *avance*, *enherytaunce*, *grevauunce*; 656–9) in Jhesus' speech where it most certainly is not meant to give rise to laughter. It would therefore appear that the *Croxton Play of the Sacrament*, as indeed the N.Town pageants and the *Digby Mary Magdalene* and *Wisdom*, use Latin and Latinate diction in such a way that, although it can be used to enhance the comedy of negative characters, the language in itself is not criticised nor is it in itself comic. From this cursory glance at these East Anglian fifteenth-century plays it appears that the aureate style and Latin were aspects of language which the authors, and therefore presumably also the intended audiences, did, at the very least, not object to and, in fact, very probably enjoyed. These are some caveats against extending our modern tastes to a fifteenth-century audience without further ado. In fact, perhaps the modern audience's 'animosity to' and 'irritation with Mercy's Latinate jargon' has been overly emphasised.¹⁷ I, for one, find that Mercy's opening speech, as for instance in the passage below, induces neither of those two feelings and that indeed his language is not so Latinate as to be particularly difficult to comprehend.

I haue be þe very mene for yowr restytucion.
 Mercy ys my name, þat mornyth for yowr offence.
 Dyverte not yowrsylffe in tyme of temtacyon,
 Pat 3e may be acceptable to Gode at yowr goyng hence.

Be grett mercy of Gode, þat ys of most preemynence,
 Be medyacyon of Owr Lady þat ys euer habundante
 To þe synfull creature þat wyll repent hys necligence.
 I prey Gode at yowr most nede þat mercy be yowr defendawnte. 17–24

This is, of course, a very subjective opinion, but it cannot be denied that Mercy's speech here contains many words of Latin origin.

Therefore, if Mercy does indeed lessen the Latinity of his speeches towards the end of the play, a strong case could still be made to the effect that the playwright was in sympathy with the more Lollard stance which favoured English to Latin for religious discourse. However, it is by no means so clear to me that Mercy's final speech is any less Latinate than his opening speech. On the contrary.

In order to analyse Mercy's speech, and that of the Vices, some useful distinctions can be made to clarify the various Latinate elements that are used in the play.¹⁸ The Latinate speech of Mercy, and indeed of Mankind in a state of grace, consists not only of words of Latin origin but also with a Latinate ending, such as *-(a)cyon*, e.g. *creacyon* (1) and *indygnacyon* (3) for Mercy and *propagacyon* (186) and *supportacyon* (212) for Mankind.¹⁹ To what extent these words would have been intelligible to a contemporary audience is hard to gauge, mainly because it would very much depend on the linguistic ability of the individual spectators. Many words, such as *retribucyon* (15), *temtacyon* (19), and *congrigacyon* (188) would almost certainly have been familiar to large sections of the population.²⁰ Other words were probably not so easy to understand; for example, the only example for *participable* in the *MED* is the one from *Mankind*. Yet, *participacioun* had a wider circulation which leads me to presume that *partycypable* (16) would not have been too difficult to interpret. Clearly, some of this vocabulary is quite technical — and chosen presumably for its learned connotations — but probably not incomprehensible.²¹ And some words which may strike a modern reader or spectator as unusual need not have been particularly odd or magniloquent at the time. For instance, the reference to the cleansing power of the Passion contained in 'þat blyssede lauatorye' (12) may strike the average twenty-first-century person as utterly ridiculous but *lavatorie* is glossed in the *MED* as 'a piscina', 'the great brass or bronze laver in the temple of Jerusalem', 'the washing of baptism', and 'lotion, wash'. The figurative meaning may be peculiar to *Mankind* but it is a perfectly natural extension of the accepted meaning of the word at the time and is consequently unlikely to have struck the contemporary audience as special. Another method which is used to give words a

Latinate aura is to suffix Latin endings onto English words, as in 'yt ys in spadibus' (398). Wenzel remarks that this type of macaronic verse is in fact rare in Middle English literature and its usage in *Mankind* is therefore all the more interesting.²² Characters also use Latin words, phrases, and sentences. Again, the extent to which these would have been understood depends very much on the degree of bilingualism (here naturally Latin/English) of the spectators. Some elements, such as *In nomine Patris et Filii et Spiritus Sancti* ('In the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Ghost', 544) would presumably have been intelligible to all — even people who were not bilingual — because it is the connotations of prayer and religiosity that matter here rather than the actual semantic content. It also worth noting that, although priests and monks would in all likelihood have had a better grasp of Latin than lay people (many of whom knew no Latin at all), code-switching between Latin and English also appears in poetry, scientific and medical texts, administrative and legal texts, and business accounts: it is consequently not necessarily characteristic of religious discourse.²³ In fact, some of the Latin used in *Mankind* is evidently based on legal practice. This is an important aspect to bear in mind: a Latinate or Latin word or phrase may have been perfectly comprehensible to one member of the audience but obscure to another; as a result, their appreciation of the 'Latinity' of a speech would have been very different. Consequently, it is impossible to determine the 'Latinity' of any given speech in the play with complete certainty. Is it all Latin-derived words (or, even, Latin quotations) which ought to count, or only those that would have been perceived as 'alien'? And perceived as 'alien' by whom? I shall look at both features but nevertheless my decisions will necessarily be impressionistic to some degree, although the quotations in the *MED* and *OED* give a fair indication of how common words were in written discourse. For now, I shall assess the 'Latinity' by these 'lowest common denominator' standards, as it were, but it should be borne in mind that this might not be representative of the intended (and perhaps even actual) audience of the play; a question to which I shall return later. After these preliminary remarks, I shall now turn again to the play and Mercy's speech.

It is true that Mercy's opening soliloquy is so Latinate that Newguise's term 'Englysch Laten' (124) is apt to describe it. And indeed Mercy's language is, as Dillon points out, not consistently characterised by a heavy-handed use of 'stately, polysyllabic words of Latin derivation'.²⁴ But the development is not simply from 'extreme Latinity' via 'plainer speech' to a

more modest, compromising 'Latinate mode'. It is, of course, impossible to find sufficient criteria clearly to distinguish these three levels of 'Latinity'; I shall understand 'extreme Latinity' as containing not only many words of ultimate Latin derivation but also Latinate words which seem to have been uncommon at the time. Judging by these, admittedly somewhat vague, criteria, Mercy's speech at the end of the play seems to me to be equally as Latinate as his opening lines. As mentioned above, merely counting words from Latin origin does not accurately represent how 'Latinate' a contemporary audience would have found the speeches. However, a count of the words of ultimate Latin origin in Mercy's first eight and last eight lines demonstrates that there is no diminished use of such vocabulary: eleven at the beginning and fifteen at the end.²⁵ This seems to counter the claim of a watered-down or reduced 'Latinity' at the very end of the play. And this is true not just for Mercy's last eight lines. Indeed, how could one describe lines such as 'Aryse now and go wyth me in thys deambulatorye [*walk*]. | Inclyne yowyr capacite; my doctrine ys conuenient [*appropriate, pertinent*]' (843–4),²⁶ 'Mankend, 3e were obliuyows of my doctrine monytorye' (879) and 'Wyrschepyll sofereyns, I hawe do my propirte: | Mankynd ys deliuaryd by my fauerall [*well-disposed, benevolent*] patrocynye [*protection*]' (902–903) but as 'Englysch Latyn'?

The supposed 'extreme Latinity' of the opening speech, in fact, relies on the whole on Latinate words that seem to have been in fairly wide and general circulation. The only possible examples of uncommon words are *dysobedyenc* (3, only attested in Lydgate and *Arthur* before *Mankind*), *obsequyouse* (5, not attested in *MED* outside *Mankind*), *partycypable* (16, not attested outside *Mankind* although *participacioun* is more widely attested), *dyverte* (19, only attested before *Mankind* in Lydgate (repeatedly), a Middle English version of Guy de Chauliac's *Grande Chirurgie*, and a translation of *De claris mulieribus*), and *premedytacyon* (44, only attested before *Mankind* in *Speculum Christiani* and a translation of Hidgen's *Polychronicon*); that is, five words in forty-four lines.²⁷ Not only are many words of Latin origin used in the final dialogue between Mercy and Mankind and in Mercy's leave-taking at the end of the play, it also seems that the form and meaning of quite a few of these words may not have been immediately recognisable to a contemporary audience. *Tymerouse* (812) is not included in the *MED* (this instance is the earliest citation in the *OED*), nor is *exspyre* (812, the earliest citation in the *OED* is from 1590). *Puerilite* is only exemplified according to the *MED* in this very instance (*Mankind* 820: this is also the earliest example in *OED*), as are *expedycius* (*Mankind* 860) and *suavius*

(*Mankind* 871: the *OED* only cites one instance from 1669). The *MED* entry for *criminous* gives only one example which is earlier than that in *Mankind* (815) and then one more example from around 1500 (the meaning is different from the more common *criminal*). *Iterat* (*Mankind* 821) is only attested in a Middle English version of Guy de Chauliac's *Grande Chirurgie* and Ripley's *The Compend of Alchemy* before *Mankind*; it seems to be a scientific term of limited circulation. This list is by no means exhaustive, and of course many words would have been more easily recognised and perhaps perceived as French rather than Latinate, e.g. *precyose* (811), *compleynt* (815), *egall* (831), *preserwyd* (851), and many more. But the examples are hopefully sufficient to demonstrate that the diction of Mercy (and, indeed of *Mankind*) at the end of the play is still characterised by 'extreme Latinity' — however hard it is to qualify that concept. Of course, the final scene between Mercy and *Mankind*, and Mercy's epilogue are much longer than Mercy's opening speech, so it is perhaps normal that there should be more instances of uncommon Latinate words in these longer scenes. Yet the fact remains that towards the end of the play the audience is repeatedly confronted not only with words from Latin origin but also with many Latinate words which they may not have come across before. Indeed, if we analyse Mercy's final 44 lines, that is, the same number of lines as his opening speech, we encounter no fewer than eight possibly unusual Latinate words — compare with the five possibilities in Mercy's opening speech: *annexion* (863) is only cited from the Rolls of Parliament outside *Mankind*; during the Middle Ages, *premyabyll* (868) is only attested in this play, and the *OED* cites only two other instances, one from around 1513, and one from 1999; *efforte* (869) is not cited in the *MED* and the earliest example in the *OED* is from c.1489; *obliuyows* (879) is only recorded in the translation of *De claris mulieribus* and twice in Capgrave's *Abstract of Sermon on the Twelve Orders under the Augustinian Rule*, as well as in *Mankind*; *monytorye* (879) is attested here and in the Proceedings of the Privy Council; *delusory* (881) is the only occurrence of the word in the *MED* and the earliest example in the *OED* dates from 1588; *fauerrall* (903) is not in the *MED*; *patrocynye* (903) is only exemplified according to the *MED* in this very instance (this is also the earliest example in the *OED*). It therefore seems evident that, if anything, the 'Latinity' of Mercy's final speeches seems to be more prominent than that of his speech at the beginning of the play; there certainly is no evolution from 'extreme Latinity' to a more moderate 'Latinity'.

Even in the course of the play Mercy's speech can be very generously sprinkled with Latin-derived words, e.g. 'A best doth after hys naturall instytucion; | 3e may conseyue by there dysporte and behauour, | Per joy ande delyte ys in derysyon' (166–8), 'Se þe grett pacyence of Job in tribulacyon' (286), and 'My inwarde affliccyon zeldeth me tedyouse wnto your presens' (740). In the first eight lines of Mercy's three long speeches within the play (162–85, 277–309, and 734–71) I found, respectively, twelve words, eleven words, and no fewer than seventeen words that ultimately derive from Latin roots.²⁸ The *caveat* that the quantity these Latinate words alone does not qualify the 'Latinity' of the speeches is still to be borne in mind; nevertheless, the numbers do not indicate a particularly 'plain' English and, in fact, the number of Latinate words in these passages is as high or higher than that at the beginning of the play (eleven).

I have looked at slightly larger extracts of these three speeches (162–77, 277–91, 734–47; 44 lines in total) to reach the same number of lines of Mercy's opening speech.²⁹ Overall, the ratio of possibly uncommon Latinate words is a little higher in these speeches than in the opening monologue: there are seven instances compared to the five at the beginning of the play. Moreover, a very interesting pattern emerges: the earlier lines contain few words which probably were not well-known, whereas the ratio in the later extract is much higher. In fact, the one possibly unusual word in the first two extracts is *instytucion* (166) because, although *institucioun* is common in Middle English writing, the meaning 'inherent disposition, nature' is unique to *Mankind*. In the last speech, however, we encounter six possibly unusual words: the only quotations in *MED* for *nutriment* (739) other than the one from *Mankind* are from Pecock, and three medical sources (namely a Middle English version of Guy de Chauliac's *Grande Chirurgie*, a Middle English version of John Arderne's *Practica de fistula in ano*, and a collection of surgical treatises); *flexybull* (741) is attested in a translation of Higden's *Polychronicon*, Hoccleve's *Regement of Princes*, and the *Speculum sacerdotale*; the *MED* only cites *Mankind* (742) for *apprehensible* — the earliest instance on the OED dates from 1631; there is no *MED* entry for *passyble* (744) and the meaning of *passable* is not appropriate for the instance in *Mankind*; the verb *discomenden* only has two quotations on top of the *Mankind* examples (183, 746); *dyspectuose* (747) is the only quotation in *MED*. The 'Latinity' of these speeches in the course of the play therefore does not appear to be reduced to the degree that we can speak of 'plain speech'. Moreover, it is

to be noted that there seems to be a development towards more 'extreme Latinity' towards the end of the play.

On the other hand, the frequency of Latinate words in Mercy's shorter speeches seems to be somewhat lower: only seven in the first eight (non-continuous) lines Mercy addresses to the Vices; none of them seems to have been uncommon.³⁰ It therefore appears that, to some extent, at least in the middle of the play, Mercy uses Latinate words more consistently in soliloquies or direct interaction with the audience, but less so in his interaction with the other characters. His language to the Vices in particular is relatively plain, e.g. 'Hye yow forth on fote, brother, in Godys name!' (68). Mankind is also addressed with some rather plain English, e.g. 'Yf a man haue an hors and kepe hym not to hye, | He may then reull hym at hys own dysyere' (241-2). It would be rash to emphasise this pattern too much as most of Mercy's speech to Mankind is heavily Latinate and even the Vices are addressed with some very Latinate lines (e.g. 122-3; quoted below). If Mercy's speeches in the scenes with the Vices are less Latinate, it is perhaps partly because he hardly gets a word in edge-wise: between the appearance of Mischief (at 45) and the departure of Mischief and New Guise, Nowadays, and Nought (at 161) he speaks a mere 16 lines whereas the Vices divide 101 lines between them. His Latinate language is, however, primarily related to the content of the speech: it is used mainly when Mercy instructs the audience and/or Mankind but not so much when he chides the Vices. This is not surprising: medieval code-switching often has the function of differentiating textual categories, here the sermon, or at least an overtly didactic genre from more day-to-day interactions.³¹ Furthermore, a mixture of Latin and English in sermons can be linked with specific topics, such as calls for repentance, and it would appear that here the Latinate diction reflects that practice; after all, Mercy in the latter part of the play is mainly concerned with Mankind's need for repentance.³² The relation between the Latinate style and the genre and topic explains the little lull after Mercy's opening soliloquy. All this shows that there is no evolution in the 'Latinity' of Mercy's speech from 'extreme' via plain speech to a less exaggerated 'Latinity' at the end. Instead, although Mercy can speak in a plainer style when the content requires it, his use of Latin-derived words remains more or less constant throughout the play; if any development is noted in Mercy's diction it should be an increase towards the end of the play in the use of words from Latin origin and especially of words which were possibly uncommon at the time and

thus more likely to have been perceived as ‘Latinated’ by a contemporary audience.

Another fact which argues against a decrease in Mercy’s Latinated mode at the end vis-à-vis the beginning of the play is that Mercy does not use any Latin as such in his opening speech, whereas he interlaces his speeches towards the end of the play fairly liberally with Latin. These consist of full lines, as in lines 826, 850, 866, and 901–902, and macaronic lines, where Latin and English are mixed, as in lines 830, 834, 862, 882, 894, 912, and 914. Incidentally, the final line of the play is ‘And hawe to 3our porcyon *vitam eternam*. Amen!’ (‘life everlasting’, 914): Mercy closes the play with Latin. Some of this Latin is translated, for instance, ‘*Vade et jam amplius noli peccare*’ (‘Go, and now sin no more’, 850) is translated not once but twice as ‘Go and syn no more’ (852, 853). In most cases, however, the English text does not translate or paraphrase the Latin, e.g. ‘The justyce of God wyll as I wyll, as hym sylfe doth precyse [*state definitely*]: | *Nolo mortem peccatoris*, *inquit*, yff he wyll be redusyble [*reclaimable*]’ (‘I desire not the death of the sinner, he said’, 833–4) and ‘The prowerbe seyth, *Jacula prestita minus ledunt*’ (‘Darts which are expected hurt less’, 882) is not glossed in the surrounding English either.³³ Clearly, it is not only biblical Latin that is not translated, e.g. an unknown versifier’s *Lex et natura, Cristus et omnia jura* | *Damnant ingratum, lugent eum fore natum* (‘Law and nature, Christ and all justice | Condemn the ungrateful, lament that he was born’, 754–5) is also not translated.³⁴ The use of Latin, whether with or without English support, increases the Latinated mode of Mercy’s speech at the end of the play quite emphatically, for not only does he not use any Latin in his opening soliloquy, he does not use very much in the course of the play either. Mercy’s first use of Latin occurs in his first encounter with Mankind: ‘For þer ys euer a batell betwyx þe soull and þe body: | *Vita hominis est milicia super terram*’ (‘The life of man upon earth is warfare’, 227–8). His second use of Latin quotation (292) is, incidentally, not translated or paraphrased into English in the text. We then have to wait till lines 754–5 for Mercy’s next use of Latin. In this same speech we also find ‘*Vanitas vanitatum*, all ys but a vanyte’ (‘Vanity of vanities’, 767) and ‘My predylecte son, where be ye? Mankynde, *vbi es*’ (‘where are you?’, 771). It is therefore evident that there is a marked increase in Mercy’s use of Latin towards the end of the play and a conspicuous lack of Latin on his part at the beginning of the play.³⁵ Here, again, the fact that in the second half of the play Mercy is primarily concerned with Mankind’s need for repentance may explain the increase in the use of Latin in this part of

the play. All this, together with the findings on the use of Latinate vocabulary, shows that it is not possible to claim that Mercy returns to a simplified or less exaggerated 'Latinity' at the end of the play. It is consequently unlikely that this play represents 'a plea for a middle way among preachers which would avoid the exclusive excesses of Latinity and admit the necessity of some plain English'.³⁶

If we grant the above, namely that the play does not seem to be opposed to Latinate or macaronic English-Latin discourse, how can we account for the negative characters' reaction to Mercy's (and, to a lesser extent, the virtuous protagonist's) speech? That the negative characters use such language is in itself not noteworthy, as this is something we also find in other fifteenth-century East Anglian plays, as shown above. What makes *Mankind* unusual, however, is that the evil characters clearly mock Latinate and macaronic speech: this is unquestionable. But it is worth pointing out that the Vices seem to parody aspects of Latinate speech which have not in fact been used by Mercy, although Mercy sometimes uses those aspects later in the play. The most important feature of this 'proleptic parody', i.e. parody which makes fun of something which has not (yet) happened in the play, is the fact that the Vices use Latin before Mercy does. Thus Mischief's fusion of Latin and English in 'Corn *seruit* ['serves for'] *bredibus*, chaff *horsibus*, straw *frybusque*' (57), 'Chaff *horsybus et reliqua*' ('and the rest', 60) and 'And so forth, *et cetera*' ('and so forth', 63) attacks an imaginary aspect of Mercy's speech. Firstly, Mercy has not yet used Latin. Secondly, Mercy does not suffix Latin endings to Germanic words, unlike Mischief.³⁷ This may seem like a pedantic detail but even a modern audience, presumably on average less well acquainted with Latin or the aureate style than a medieval one, immediately perceives that *horsibus* (57) is funny whereas *indynacyon* (3) is not, and thus automatically registers the difference between the two morphological processes. Later on Nought also uses this linguistic fusion, e.g. 'on yowr hedybus' (399), and, here too, there is no equivalent aspect in Mercy's or Mankind's speech. A leaf is missing at the entry of New Guise, Nowadays, and Nought, but it would appear, again, that however Latinate Mercy's language may be, the parody of the use of Latin in itself is unprovoked by Mercy's speech:

Mercy Mercy ys my name by denomynacyon [*designation*].
 I conseyue 3e haue but a lytyll fauour in my communycacyon.
 New Gyse Ey, ey! yowr body ys full of Englysch Laten.
 I am aferde yt wyll brest.
 'Prauo te' ('I curse you') quod þe bocher onto me.

122-6

It is only much later in the play with the Vices' reaction to Mercy's exclamation 'Mankynde, *vbi es?*' ('where are you?', 771) that they can be said directly to mock his use of Latin:

Myscheff Wyll 3e here? He cryeth euer 'Mankynde, *vbi est?*'
 New Gyse Hic hyc, hic hic, hic hic, hic hic!
 Bat ys to sey, here, here, here! 774–6

And even here the Vices' use of Latin goes beyond Mercy's, as Nowaday continues

Yf 3e wyll haue Mankynde, how *domine, domine, dominus!*
 [‘O Lord, O Lord, Lord’]
 3e must speke to þe schryue [*sheriff*] for a *cape corpus*,
 [‘arrest the body’]
 Ellys 3e must be fayn to retorn wyth *non est inventus*.
 [‘(he) is not found’]
 779–81

The Vices', and indeed Titivillus's use of Latin is not triggered by Mercy's. This does not undermine the comedy value of their language by any means, but their language is so evidently exaggerated and differentiated from Mercy's that it becomes questionable whether they effectively parody his language at all (whatever their intentions). This is an important aspect of the language conflict of this play, and one that has not often been remarked on.³⁸ In my opinion, it indicates that the linguistic parody of the Vices and the devil is shown to be unwarranted, the implication being that the language of true virtuous clerks, such as Mercy, is beyond the reach of parody (and perhaps also of criticism).

Occasionally, the Latin of the negative characters is not easy to understand, e.g. the meaning of *pravo* (126) is not entirely clear and Nought's *Estis vos pecuniatus* ('do you have money', 471) is grammatically incorrect.³⁹ It is clear that Nought's grasp of Latin leaves something to be desired: he writes *Carici* (687) for *curia* ('court'), *regitalis* (689) for *regis* ('of the king'), *nullateni* (690) for *nullatenus* ('not at all'); no wonder Mischief mockingly calls him 'owr Tulli' (692). The meaning of Mercy's Latin is, of course, always clear and his grammar correct. The register of Mercy's, and indeed of the virtuous protagonist's Latin is nearly always biblical or related to prayer: that is, it is nearly always clerical.⁴⁰ By contrast, some of the negative characters' Latin words and phrases do not seem to belong to any professional register, e.g. *Osculare fundamentum* ('Kiss my arse', 142), the exclamation *ven, ven* ('come, come', 426, 433), and 'to yow I sey

caueatis ('beware', 476). Note that the first two of these instances are also ungrammatical as one needs the imperative and not the infinitive in *osculare fundamentum*, and in the second example *veni* has undergone apocope. One might also expect the imperative in the third example, although, strictly speaking the present subjunctive *caveatis* is admissible in this context.

This is not to deny that the negative characters' Latin is often used as a parody of religious discourse. New Guise quotes the Psalms (324–6). Titivillus' entry line '*Ego sum dominancium dominus* ('I am the Lord of lords') and my name ys Titivillus' (475) is based on biblical uses of *dominus dominantium*. Nowadays transposes *noli me tangere* ('do not touch me', 512) from Jesus Christ to 'Master Woode of Fullburn' (511). But the Vices and the devil also use Latin that seems characteristic of academic debate, e.g. *Ita vere, magister* ('Indeed, master', 473), *Ego probo sic* ('I prove [it] thus', 478), and perhaps also *ad omnia quare* ('at every why', 578). Another notable aspect in the Vices' use of Latin(ate language) is the parody of legal language in their mock court session, e.g. Mischief's 'Nowadays, mak proclamacyon, | And do yt *sub forma jurys*, dasarde [fool]!' ('in the legal manner', 665–6), 'Here ys blottybus in blottis, | *Blottorum blottibus istis*' (680–81), Nought's flawed *Anno regni regitalis* | *Edwardi nullateni* ('In the year of the reign of the kingly | Edward the Not-At-All', 689–90), and Nowadays' *cape corpus* ('arrest the body', 780) and *non est inventus* ('[he] is not found', 781).⁴¹ Two aspects of interest for the present discussion come to the fore: the Vices' and the devil's use of Latin is not limited to the religious register (indeed, the legal register is very prominent) and they use Latin (and also Latinate vocabulary) amongst themselves. This undermines the notion that they parody Mercy's use of Latin, mainly because Mercy's is on the whole limited to the religious register, but also because Latin seems to be an innate feature of the negative characters' diction and not something which is necessarily brought out as a reaction to Mercy (or, indeed, to Mankind).⁴²

If they do not attack Mercy's Latin, or, indeed, his Latinate speech, what do they attack? The playwright seems to concentrate on their inappropriate or nonsensical use of Latin, as in *Osculare fundamentum* ('Kiss my arse', 142) and *Anno regni regis nulli* ('In year of the reign of no king', 693). The element of parody lies not so much in the inappropriateness of religious or legal language in itself, but rather in the Vices' and devil's inappropriate use of such appropriate language. The problem which the author appears to highlight is the danger of the wrong

people, that is, the sinful, using the right language, not the possibility that the right people, that is, the virtuous, may be using the wrong language. It is intriguing to note, here, Mankind's reaction to Newguise's first speech within his hearing. Newguise quotes from the psalms twice in these four lines — although admittedly once through the medium of the devil — yet Mankind blandly states 'I her a felow speke; wyth hym I wyll not mell [*enter into conversation*]' (327). This is an odd reaction to a speech consisting of biblical quotations, but an entirely appropriate reaction to the speaker. This reception, or rather lack of it, contrast sharply with Mankind seeking out Mercy earlier in the play, and with his assessment of Mercy's *aureate* speech ('O, yowr louely wordys to my soull are swetere þen hony', 225). The playwright demonstrates that it is impossible for Vice characters or devils to use appropriate language because of their immoral status. No matter how learned, aureate, Latinate, and grammatically correct a negative character's (or indeed a sinful person's) language may be — and, with the notable exception of Nought, their Latin is on the whole idiomatic and grammatically correct — given the absence of virtue it can never be anything other than inappropriate, flawed, and immoral.⁴³

The intentions behind and effects of the use of Latinate diction and Latin on the part of the negative characters are relatively straightforward, if not monolithic. The most important aspect is undoubtedly comedy, as in Mischief's famous 'Corn *seruit bredibus*, chaffe horsibus, straw fyrybusque' (57). This line also points up their incomprehension of, or perhaps rather their unwillingness to comprehend, the true import of Mercy's serious discourse. They also use Latin to make a false claim to authority, as when Titivillus enters with '*Ego sum dominancium dominus*' ('I am the Lord of lords', 475) followed by the anti-climactic 'and my name ys Titivillus' (475) as if the real Lord of lords would ever need to introduce himself by name. Nought's flawed legal terminology also sets up and undermines the Vices' legal authority. Nevertheless, it is difficult to demonstrate the exact intention and effect of some of their Latin, e.g. '*Ego probo sic*' ('I prove [it] thus', 478), 'þe *recumbentibus* of my jewellys' ('bashing', 496), 'þe halter brast asonder: *ecce signum*!' ('here [is] the sign', 616). To some degree it would appear that their use of Latin is superfluous, and these instances appear to show them using Latin mainly to impress: 'look, here is the sign' would have done just as well. Certainly, Titivillus' *Ego probo sic* (478) could easily be uttered in a very grand and impressive manner, and hence provide a humorous contrast with his actual methodology: 'ser New Gys, lende me a peny!' (478).⁴⁴ The rhythm of the Latin may also have been

slightly slower than that of their English, as in the example above, and in '3e pley in nomine patris, choppe!' ('in the name of the Father', 440) and 'I sey, New Gyse, Nowadays: *Estis vos pecuniatus?*' ('do you have money?', 471). This would have had the effect of making the Latin in their discourse stand out even more. Moreover, the potential for stage action is often very marked in these instances: for instance, '*ecce signum!*' ('here [is] the sign', 616) is obviously accompanied by emphatic pointing at the noose around Newguise's neck, and Nowadays' '*Ita vere, magister*' ('Indeed, master', 473) would work very well with either falsely obsequious or curtly dismissive stage action aimed at Nought. The Latin of the negative characters is evidently meant to stand out and is very much part of the theatrical display of these characters. I have not discovered an overarching reason for the switch to Latin in Mercy's and Mankind's speech, nor are the effects of such code switching always clear.⁴⁵ But there are some possible reasons and effects. Often Mercy cites the Bible in Latin, e.g. in lines 228, 826, and 834, and the notion of authority is obviously important throughout.⁴⁶ In fact, when the Latin consists of a quotation, usually from a source of authority, it is often emphatically embedded, e.g. 'as he [i.e. Job] seyde' (291), 'Dauid seyth' (396), 'As a nobyll versyfyer makyth mencyon in þis verse' (753), 'as hym sylfe [i.e. God] doth precyse [*state definitely*]' (833), 'as we rede in scrypture' (849), 'þe prowerbe seyth' (882). This stresses the authority of these Latin phrases and seems to be an element the Vices and Titivillus pick up on in their use of Latin, e.g. Newguise's inversion 'quod þe Deull to þe frerys' (325) where the devil is named as the authority. Titivillus appropriates the position of authority (if on more trivial matters) with '3e þat haue goode hors, to yow I sey *caueatis!*' ('beware', 476) and 'Now I say 3et ageyn, *caueatis!*' ('beware', 490); Mercy never claims authority in this way. Although a modern audience is apt to perceive Latin as unemotional, Mercy's use of Latin not only conjures up a sense of authority, grandeur, and solemnity, but also of urgency, as when Mercy begs '3et for my lofe ope thy lyppys and sey *Miserere mei, Deus!*' ('have mercy on me, O God', 830) and exclaims 'O pirssid Jhesu, help þou þis synfull synner to redouce! | *Nam hec est mutacio dextre Excelsi; vertit impios et non sunt*' ('this is the change of the right hand of the most High; he turns the wicked and they shall not be', 825–2). Far from being dry or alienating, Mercy's Latin is used to underline his genuine, heart-felt concern in the fate of Mankind, as indeed it is at the end of Mercy's long soliloquy lamenting the protagonist's fall. This starts emotionally ('My mynde ys dyspersyde, my body trymmelyth as þe aspen

leffe', 734) and ends with the climactic 'My predylecte son, where be ye? Mankynde, *vbi es?*' ('where are you', 771) which is filled with love as well as fear. This sense of urgency is also present in the calls to repentance which often lead to a Latin phrase, e.g. 'Thy obstinacy wyll exclude the fro þe glorius perpetuite. | 3et for my lofe ope thy lyppys and sey *Miserere mei, Deus!*' ('have mercy on me, O God', 829–80) and 'Be repentant here, trust not þe ovr of deth; thynke on þis lessun: | *Ecce nunc tempus acceptabile, ecce nunc dies salutis*' ('Behold, now is the acceptable time: behold, now is the day of salvation', 865–6). It is also to be borne in mind that the liturgical connotations of biblical extracts such as *Ecce nunc tempus acceptabile, ecce nunc dies salutis* ('Behold, now is the acceptable time: behold, now is the day of salvation', 866), which was used in the liturgy on Ash Wednesday and on the first Sunday of Lent, would possibly have been at least as important as their purely semantic meaning.⁴⁷ Moreover, it seems likely that the Latin served an ornamental purpose as code switching, 'like alliteration or other rhetorical strategies, can provide stylistic emphasis'.⁴⁸ Unlike the negative characters' Latin, the Latin of virtuous characters does not normally go hand in hand with emphatic stage action. Instead, it manages to combine more or less static formality and dignity with that sense of concern and urgency on the part of Mercy; Mankind uses Latin only four times: twice to pray (544, 554), once to remind himself that he is ash (321), and once to point out that a shovel is not proper defence against sin (397) — it seems to be used to underline the solemnity yet vulnerable precariousness of his state of grace. As the English which the virtuous Mankind and Mercy use is aureate, the contrast between the rhythm of the Latin and their English is not as pronounced as it is for the negative characters. Thus, whereas the Vices' and Titivillus' Latin tends to stick out, Mercy's and Mankind's use of Latin does not call attention to itself in quite the same way: it may be more authoritative, emphatic, formal, and urgent than the surrounding English, but it is a coherent, integral part of their discourse. The playwright, in my opinion, has very skilfully used the stylistic effects and dramatic possibilities of aureate speech and of Latin to emphasise the fundamental difference between the negative characters' and the virtuous characters' speech and disposition.

The matter of language in *Mankind* is intricately related to the question of audience, as I have already mentioned. Recently the notion that *Mankind* is a crude play for country bumpkins has been seriously and, I think, conclusively undermined.⁴⁹ Several authors have pointed out that

the witty and serious use of Latin 'require[s] an understanding of Latin if one is to appreciate the humour and comprehend the message of the play',⁵⁰ that is to say, at least part of the audience was educated and bilingual. This type of audience would presumably not have perceived Mercy's diction as alienatingly Latinate. Conversely, it is often assumed that the Vices' attack on Mercy's use of Latin and Latinate speech is inherently attractive to the audience.⁵¹ This, in itself, is perhaps somewhat one-sided. Certainly, their language is funny and entertaining but it is also undignified, inappropriate, and crude — perhaps it repulses quite as much as it attracts the audience. From this, it is only a small step away to claim that an audience able to appreciate such parody of Latin and Latinate speech was in all likelihood uneducated,⁵² implying that at least part of the audience was uneducated and not bilingual, and would consequently have perceived Mercy's speech as alienatingly Latinate. It is true that some of the humour contained in the Vices' and Titivillus' use of Latin and Latinate language is evident to all, regardless of an ability to understand Latin. Thus, for example, the comedy of 'Here ys blottybus in blottis, | Blottorum blottibus istis' (680–81), especially if pronounced with true Blackadder b's, and 'Osculare fundamentum!' ('Kiss my arse!', 142), accompanied as it undoubtedly was by appropriate stage actions, does not depend on the audience understanding Latin or recognising Latin endings. That in itself, however, is no proof of an uneducated or even mixed audience as the humour is, if anything, enhanced by an understanding of Latin. Similarly Nought's garbled Latin records of the court scene, '*carici tenta ... | Anno regni regis nulli*' ('court [*corrupted form*] having been held ... | In the year of the reign of no king', 687–93) may have been read by Mischief in such a way that its nonsensical character came to the fore, for example, by emphasising the odd word *carici* by reading it slowly and hesitantly or by repeating it. However, the joke becomes even more funny if one realises that Nought's scribal attempts mimic a customary legal formula as in *curia ... tenta ... anno regni regis Henrici liiij* ('the court ... having been held ... in the fifty-fourth year of the reign of the king Henry').⁵³ It is moreover unlikely that the playwright wanted the audience not to notice the careful swipes at the weakness or even absence of king Edward IV contained in these Latin scribal efforts with references to *Edwardi nullateni* (roughly 'of Edward the Not-At-All' 690) and *anno regni regis nulli* ('in the year of the reign of no king', 693).⁵⁴ Although certain aspects of these examples would presumably have appealed even to non-Latinate members of the audience, knowledge of Latin significantly

increases one's appreciation of the games with language in these instances. This leads me to presume that the playwright's intended audience was educated and Latinate.⁵⁵ Indeed, Mercy treats the audience as if it consisted of reasonable, intelligent people who do not need to have everything spelled out ('I nede not to speke of yt, yowr reson wyll tell it yow', 184), which is perhaps rather less likely to have occurred if the audience consisted mainly of uneducated lay men (and women). In any case, the almost default link between 'low' humour with an illiterate audience, which has been used to ascribe *Mankind* as fit for the uneducated, is a fallacy, as we find plenty of examples of bawdy, crude humour in, for example, John Heywood's and Nicholas Udall's plays which were most certainly not aimed at an uneducated audience.⁵⁶ On the other hand, the play itself indicates a mixed audience as Mercy (a reliable witness) greets the audience with 'O 3e souerens þat sytt and 3e brothern þat stonde ryght wppe' (29). This may, however, merely acknowledge different ranks within an institution, for example, the Master and Fellows versus the students of a Cambridge college, or within a religious guild or household, rather than a distinction between secular and religious and/or uneducated and learned.⁵⁷ In fact, given the games played with language in *Mankind*, knowledge of Latin would not only improve the experience for the audience but very probably the performance by the actors as well. In my view, *Mankind* is a play that revels in its use of aureate diction and Latin and which was intended for an audience which would be able and inclined to appreciate such use of language, that is, an educated audience which was favourably disposed towards Latin and aureate diction. There is too little information to situate the play in a particular kind of household or institution, but maybe some of its jocular pseudo-Latinity points towards an audience and/or cast containing youngsters who had learned or were in the process of mastering Latin, perhaps undergraduates at a Cambridge college (who were often obliged to speak Latin at all times), pupils at a school, or novices at a religious institution.⁵⁸ The fact that there are no female characters in *Mankind* and that the references to the audience do not specifically mention or address women could also indicate an all-male audience, such as Cambridge colleges, schools, many religious institutions, and even some religious guilds, would easily provide.⁵⁹ The Latin and Latinate diction in *Mankind* has obvious connections with the Bible, liturgy, law, and to a lesser degree even with medicine, but this does not suffice to determine the intended setting and audience. As Primers and church service books, which included the most basic devotional texts,

the matins book and the Psalter, were used to teach pupils to read (without necessarily understanding what was read) at least some of the Latin in the play would have been familiar to any 'reading' or 'song' school-educated member in the audience.⁶⁰ Some of these texts were also common in lay devotion: for example, Walter Hilton recommended the Pater Noster and Psalms for souls seeking comfort.⁶¹ And although there seems to have been much variation in medieval liturgy, some of the Latin would almost certainly have carried strong seasonal connotations as they were used in the liturgy on specific occasions: *Memento, homo, quod cinis es et in cinerem reuerteris* ('Remember, O man, that you are ashes and shall return into ashes', 321) probably recalled Ash Wednesday (the beginning of Lent); *Nolo mortem peccatoris* ('I desire not the death of the wicked', 834) the first Sunday in Lent; and *Vade et jam amplius noli peccare* ('Go, and now sin no more' 850) the fourth Sunday in Lent. On the other hand, it is doubtful that the secular congregation would have been able to hear, let alone understand, much of the liturgy; consequently, the impact of these lines would probably have been more potent for those well-acquainted with the liturgy (and the Bible). A smattering of legal and even medical learning would have been taught at many grammar schools and more thoroughly so at the universities.⁶² Most religious institutions, and certainly great landowners such as the Benedictine monastery at Bury St Edmunds, would have had members with legal and medical knowledge, and a knowledge of some medical and legal terms and phrases by no means excludes a religious institution as a candidate for the originally envisaged setting. John Marshall has argued for the patronage of a religious guild, and it is interesting to note that these guilds sometimes also had schools and appointed schoolmasters.⁶³ All these institutions would therefore appear to have been possible settings. Yet, although some of the Latin and Latinate humour in the play may point towards schoolboys or undergraduates, it is not a play about education.⁶⁴ Nor is its use of Latin by negative characters confined to uncomprehending recitations or consistently characterised by grammatical errors, which one might expect if the play were about and for people learning Latin; in fact, the meaning of the Latin is usually important. Thus, Newguise's citation of Psalm 17: 26, 17, *Cum sancto sanctus eris et cum peruerso peruerteris* ('with the holy thou wilt be holy and with the perverse thou wilt be perverted', 324), has various effects. Firstly, taken out of context of its surrounding verses, the interpretation of the Latin changes. In the psalm it is clear that it is God's reward or judgement that is the issue, that is, God will reward the virtuous

but punish the sinful. Without this context, however, the literal translation ‘with the holy thou wilt be holy and with the perverse thou wilt be perverted’ becomes uppermost. Surely, this contrast between its intended meaning, within the psalm, and its literal meaning, emphasised when quoting these lines out of context, is meant to be noted and to create an element of comedy. Thus, not only the meaning, but even the original context of the Latin, are important. Moreover, it links back to Mankind’s *Memento, homo, quod cinis es et in cinerem reuerteris* (‘Remember, O man, that you are ashes and shall return into ashes’, 321) through rhyme. This linking highlights a certain clash in meaning: Mankind stresses a fundamental, unchangeable quality of man (dust and ashes), whereas Newguise advocates human changeability. The function of this line therefore relies heavily on the audience’s understanding of Latin, and even on their recognition of the perverted use of the psalm by the Vice. This kind of knowledge need not indicate an audience of clergy, but it would seem to indicate a well-educated audience with good grasp of Latin, the Psalms and other books of the Bible (e.g. the Gospels, Job, Ezekiel, Samuel, Ecclesiastes) and the liturgy, and some knowledge of legal phraseology.⁶⁵ Indeed, by far the majority of the Latin words and phrases in the play are not translated, which seems to point to a bilingual audience. If *Mankind* was indeed intended for an well-educated, Latin-literate audience, this would ensure that it is highly probable that the aureate diction of Mercy, and Mercy’s use of Latin as well, was not perceived as difficult to comprehend and alienating. It is much more probable that the intended audience appreciated such high-style linguistic display by the good characters and enjoyed the play with language(s) which characterises the bad characters’ diction.

What are the implications of this re-assessment of Mercy’s and the negative characters’ Latinate language and use of Latin for Dillon’s overall argument about the linguistic debate in *Mankind*? On the one hand, I agree that the inappropriate use of Latin by the Vices and Titivillus is used to highlight the dangers of deconstructing ‘words into material signs detachable from the truth they seem to embody’.⁶⁶ In fact, the notion of words as material signs or objects is linked with the Vices early on in the play when Nowadays urges Mercy ‘Now opyn yowr sachell wyth Laten wordys’ (133). And indeed Mercy’s use of Latin at the end of the play shows that the author did not intend ‘to prove the word’s inherent emptiness’ but rather to demonstrate the complicated but crucial link between speaker, word, and meaning.⁶⁷ On the other hand, I would

argue, against Dillon, that the 'Latinity' of Mercy's diction is enhanced, becomes more extreme, if you will, towards the end of the play — and that Latin becomes more prominent in his speeches as the play progresses. The latter development is undeniable and seriously undermines her argument that the author of the play seems to argue for a position of compromise between the orthodox use of Latin and the heterodox use of the vernacular in contemporary religion. Rather, Mercy re-appropriates and firmly establishes Latin and Latinate diction as the proper religious language towards the end of the play. Moreover, the Vices' attack on the use of Latin and Latinate diction, no matter how comic, is unwarranted and might well imply that the real-life (Lollard) criticism of the use of Latin and Latinate diction in contemporary religion is equally unjustified and undignified. I would not go so far as to claim that *Mankind* is a piece of anti-Lollard propaganda — as, for instance, the near-contemporary *Croxton Play of the Sacrament* (probably written less than ten years before *Mankind* and also of East Anglian origin) may well have been — although there are other elements in the play with an anti-Lollard ring to them.⁶⁸ Thus, given that *Mankind's* fall is closely connected with his failure to attend church and his decision to pray in his field instead, it is interesting to note that Lollards often maintained that prayer in open air was as good as, or even better than, prayer in church.⁶⁹ Here, again, the implications of the play are, if anything, anti-Lollard. But even though the play does not present us with an open attack on Lollardy, I should say that the author of *Mankind* was very much on the Latin side of the contemporary debate on religious discourse and carefully undermined the vernacular position.

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NOTES

1. See, for instance, Paula Neuss 'Active and Idle Language: Dramatic Images in *Mankind*' in *Medieval Drama* edited Neville Denny (Stratford-upon-Avon Studies 16; London: Edward Arnold, 1973) 40–67 and Kathleen M. Ashley 'Titivillus and the Battle of Words in *Mankind*' *Annuaire Mediaevale* 16 (1975) 128–50.
2. *The Macro Plays: 'The Castle of Perseverance', 'Wisdom', 'Mankind'* edited Mark Eccles EETS 262 (1969).
3. Janette Dillon *Language and Stage in Medieval and Renaissance England* (Cambridge UP, 1998) 54–69 and Janette Dillon 'Mankind and the Politics of "Englysh Latyn"' in *Medievalia et Humanistica: Studies in Medieval & Renaissance Culture New Series* 20 (1993) 41–64. Dillon does not define the term *Latinity*,

and does not specify which criteria she uses to determine the 'Latinity' of a speech.

4. Anne Hudson *The Premature Reformation: Wycliffite Texts and Lollard History* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1988) 447–53 at 453 and Gail McMurray Gibson *The Theater of Devotion: East Anglian Drama and Society in the Late Middle Ages* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1989) 30–31.
5. Note that Dillon limits the heterodoxy of the play to the language as the quotation continues: 'while wishing himself to preach a doctrine that was broadly orthodox.'; Dillon 'Mankind and the Politics of "Englysh Laten"' 47.
6. Dillon *Language and Stage* 68.
7. Richard Beadle 'Monk Thomas Hyngham's hand in the Macro manuscript' in *New Science out of Old Books: Studies in Manuscripts and Early Printed Books in Honour of A.I. Doyle* edited Richard Beadle and A.J. Piper (Aldershot: Scolar Press, 1995) 315–37.
8. John Norton-Smith *John Lydgate: Poems* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1966) 192, and W.A. Davenport *Fifteenth-century English Drama: The Early Moral Plays and their Literary Relations* (Cambridge: Brewer, 1984) 10, 38, 135.
9. Norton-Smith *John Lydgate* 194.
10. Note that most if not all of the Latinate words in the plays (and elsewhere of course) were borrowed through French or Anglo-Norman, and it is therefore possible that they were sometimes perceived primarily as French, rather than Latinate. It is extremely difficult to determine when a word would have been perceived as one rather than the other, although occasionally its usual context or form can be of help. For instance, words commonly used in religious contexts are more likely to have been associated with Latin than French.
11. Note that Granger also presumes that the Latin in the N.Town Play 'would have seemed normal or even unremarkable to the fifteenth-century audience'; Penny Granger *The N.Town Play: Drama and Liturgy in Medieval East Anglia* (Cambridge: Brewer, 2009) 34. The question of audience is a complicated one but I shall return to it later in the article.
12. *The N-Town Play: Cotton MS Vespasian D. 8, Vol. 1: Text* edited Stephen Spector *EETS SS 11* (1991).
13. *The Late Medieval Religious Plays of Bodleian Mss Digby 133 and E Museo 160* edited Donald C. Baker, John L. Murphy and Louis B. Hall Jr. *EETS 283* (1982).
14. *Debonaire* (adj.) meaning 'gentle, courteous' and such like seems to have been a common word, but this particular form with final *-us* is not attested elsewhere.
15. It is not clear whether perhaps scribal changes may have obscured the meaning of this dog-Latin. It evidently is meant to be nonsensical to some degree but

- perhaps some sense was meant to be made from it, e.g. 'werwolfforum | Standgardum lamba' (1193–4) seems to refer to the simile of priests as shepherds; see Baker, Murphy, and Hall *Digby* 211 and Davenport *Fifteenth-century English Drama* 124.
16. *Medieval Drama: An Anthology* edited Greg Walker (Oxford: Blackwell, 2000).
 17. Dillon 'Mankind and the Politics of "English Laten"' 42–3. Davenport, careful to distinguish the modern and fifteenth-century appreciation of Mercy's opening speech, claims that 'It seems now pompous and pretentious'; *Fifteenth-century English Drama* 38. Eccles simply has 'The speeches of Mercy are tedious, but moralizing must be expected in a moral play.'; Eccles *Macro Plays* xlv. Heap, reporting on actual performance, does not entirely contradict this sentiment but he does stress that 'there is a certain formal beauty to his lines when spoken aloud, and more room for warmth and emotion than might be imagined'; Carl Heap 'On Performing Mankind' in *Medieval English Theatre* 4 (1982) 93–103 at 94 – I should like to thank Richard Beadle for the reference to this article.
 18. This discussion is largely based on Diller's analysis of code-switching in medieval drama, and on his discussion of *Mankind* in particular; Hans-Jürgen Diller 'Code-switching in medieval English drama' *Comparative Drama* 31 (1997/1998) 506–37.
 19. Diller 'Code-switching' 530.
 20. The *OED* gives references for *retribution* to Wyclif, Langland, and Lydgate and the *MED* gives six examples which are earlier than *Mankind*. Similarly for *temptation* the *OED* gives quotations from Wyclif, *Ancrene Riwe*, *Ayenbite of Inwyt*, and Lydgate and the *MED* adds to this further examples from Chaucer, Mannyng, Rolle, Hoccleve, and *Dives et Pauper*. For *congregation* the *OED* cites Chaucer and *Cursor Mundi* to which the *MED* adds examples from the Wycliffite *Lantern of Light* and the Paston Letters amongst others.
 21. See also Diller 'Code-switching' 531.
 22. Siegfried Wenzel *Macaronic sermons: bilingualism and preaching in late-medieval England* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1994) 4.
 23. Hebert Schendl 'Mixed-language texts as data and evidence in English historical linguistics' in *Studies in the History of the English Language: A Millennial Perspective* edited Donka Minkova and Robert Stockwell (Berlin: Mouton de Gruyter, 2002) 51–78 at 55.
 24. Dillon *Language and Stage* 63–5 and Ashley 'Titivillus' 131.
 25. The instances are: *fownder* (1), *creacyon* (1), *magnyfyede* (2), *dysobedyenc* (3), *indygnacyon* (3), *crucyfyede* (4), *obsequyouse* (5), *seruyce* (5), *aplyede* (5), *revyuyde* (7), and *redempcyon* (8) at the beginning and *recewyd* (907), *humanite* (907), *serge* (908), *condicions* (908), *dew* (908), *examinacion* (908), *remembyr* (909), *wanite* (909),

prowyd (910), *diuerse* (910), *transmutacyon* (910), *sufficyent* (911), *proue* (911), *grant* (912), and *porcyon* (914) at the end of the play. Note that instances of Latin proper (six words in the later passage) and *angellys* (913) have not been included; they would obviously enhance the ‘Latinity’ of the later passage even more.

Many of these words, such as *founder* which is widely attested from the fourteenth century onwards, were common at the time and probably did not stand out as borrowings to contemporary speakers. Moreover, if contemporary speakers were aware of the non-Germanic origin of the words, some of these would have been perceived as French rather than Latinate. For instance, *due* is much more similar to Old French *deü*, *dû* than to Latin *debitum* (or unattested **debitum*), and *grant* likewise is much more obviously related to Anglo-Norman *graunter*, *granter* and Old French *graaunter*, *greanter*, than to Latin *credentem*. Arguably the use of many Romance words has the overall effect of making a passage seem more learned and/or elitist and/or alienating, but I shall rely mainly on words which do seem to have been uncommon at the time, and are likely to have been perceived as Latinate by a contemporary audience.

26. ‘Inclyne yowyr capacite’ probably means no more than ‘listen’; fifteenth-century understanding of *capacity* included ‘mental or intellectual receiving power’ and ‘mental ability’ (*OED* sv *capacity* 4, 5).
27. If these words were indeed barely known, and very possibly coined for the play, it would undermine Diller’s argument that Mischief’s *calcacyon* and *dalyacyon* are inherently different from Mercy’s speech because they are new-fangled; Diller ‘Code-switching’ 531.
28. They are *dylyuerance* (162), *ordynance* (164), *preue* (165), *reson* (165), *naturall* (166), *instytucion* (166), *conseyue* (167), *dysporte* (167), *joy* (168), *delyte* (168), *derysyon* (168), *dyshonour* (169) for the opening of the first medial speech; *enmys* (278), *avaunte* (278), *prey* (280), *seruante* (280), *condycyon* (281), *varyant* (281), *folly* (282), *proue* (283), *constant* (283), *perpetuall* (284), *partener* (284) for the opening of the second medial speech; *dyspersyde* (734), *trymmelyth* (734), *reuerrence* (735), *solace* (736), *cruell* (736), *vysytacyon* (736), *rude* (737), *expresse* (737), *inconvenyens* (737), *sufficyens* (738), *naturall* (739), *nutriment* (739), *odybull* (739), *affliccyon* (740), *tedyouse* (740), *presens* (740), and *flexybull* (741) for the opening of the final medial long speech. This excludes two instances of *behaviour* (167, 737), one in the first and one in the last speech, because it is merely the ending that shows French influence.

Again, many of these words were presumably not perceived as borrowings by contemporary speakers and some may well have been associated with French rather than Latin. For instance, *joy* is regularly attested from 1200 onwards and is unlikely to have been perceived as ‘foreign’ by fifteenth-century native English speakers. And even if they had realised the Romance origin of the word, they would probably have associated it with French *joie*, *joye* rather than

- with Latin *gaudium*. As such, these lists give only a very vague indication of the 'Latinate' feel these passages would have created.
29. Latin proper (292–3) has not been included; the use of Latin is discussed below.
 30. This excludes *daunce* (90) which seems to have been a Germanic borrowing into Romance.
 31. Schendl 'Mixed-language texts' 65. Note that in some texts the languages 'may be so intimately mixed or even fused that the question arises whether we are still faced with intra-sentential code-switching or rather with a – possibly institutionalised – new mixed code'; Schendl 'Mixed-language texts' 68. What we encounter here is more a 'new mixed code' than code-switching but the two are clearly closely related and can have similar functions.
 32. Wenzel *Macaronic sermons* 66. Indeed, Wenzel claims that macaronic sermons 'are products of a linguistic *aggiornamento* and a stylistic trial that runs parallel to ... the aureate diction used by some contemporary poets' (127).
 33. Although Ezekiel: 13:11 has *Nolo mortem impii* (literally 'of an impious man') rather than *peccatoris* (literally 'of a sinner'); Eccles *Macro Plays* at 226 note 834. *Peccatoris* was, however, used in the 'Italian' branch of the Vulgate and was much more common in medieval theological writings and liturgy; for a detailed discussion see Marbury B. Ogle 'Bible Text or Liturgy?' in *The Harvard Theological Review* 33 (1940) 191–224 (211–12).
 34. Although these verses are not given any source in the edition, it is to be noted that they occur in a slightly different version in the preaching handbook of Friar John of Grimestone (c.1376), as *Lex et natura, Christus, simul omnia iura | Dampnant ingratum, plangunt illum fore natum* ('Law and Nature, Christ, together with all justice | condemn the ungrateful, lament that he was born'), where they are moreover translated as 'Iesu Crist and al mankende | Dampnen þe man þat is vnkende. | An skil þat hat ben her afor | Hat weiled þat euere was he born'; Siegfried Wenzel *Preachers, Poets, and the Early English Lyric* (Princeton UP, 1986) at 128. It is therefore possible that these verses were fairly commonplace at the time *Mankind* was composed.
 35. The lack of Latin on the part of a virtuous character at the beginning of the play is a little odd. Compare, for instance, *Wisdom* where Anima uses Latin at line 17 (her opening line) and Wisdom at line 27 (his seventeenth line); Eccles *Macro Plays*.
 36. Dillon *Language and Stage* 68.
 37. Diller 'Code-switching' 530, 532.
 38. Diller also points out that Mischief's 'parody misses its target: he is unable to tell the difference between a pseudo-learned speaker of bad Latin (perhaps a schoolmaster) and Mercy, a solemn preacher in aureate English'; Diller 'Code-switching' 532.

39. Eccles *Macro Plays* at 218 note M 125–6. It does sound like a literal translation from English ‘Are you rich?’ As Sarah Carpenter points out, the Vices’ Latin has a ‘schoolboy’ feel to it, which is presumably also exemplified in those common vernacular words with Latin endings used by the Vices (private communication).
40. The exceptions are the quotation of the unknown versifier (754–5), the exclamation ‘Mankynde, *vbi es?*’ (‘where are you’ 774), the proverb (882), and *Libere welle, libere nolle* (‘freely to will, freely not to will’ 894).
41. Eccles *Macro Plays* at 225 note M 687. Note that Lydgate’s aureate English style was specifically associated with the use of non-technical Latinate vocabulary from the Vulgate or the liturgy, so that Mercy’s use of Latin can, in a way, be characterised as ‘aureate’ but not so the Vices’ use of Latin.
42. See also note 39 above. But at least none of Mercy’s Latin can be clearly linked with other registers, such as the legal profession.
43. Neuss notes the opposite, namely that the ‘the proper use of language is an essential aspect of virtuous behaviour’; Neuss ‘Active and Idle Language’ 51.
44. Note how in the late sixteenth-century *Dr Faustus* the scholars recall that the protagonist ‘was wont to make | our schools ring with *sic probo*’ (2 1–2); Christopher Marlowe *Dr Faustus* edited Roma Gill (London: Black, 2nd edition 1989; reprinted 2000).
45. Note that there also do not appear to be ‘all-encompassing causes, whether linguistic, stylistic, or psychological’ for the switch from Latin to English in macaronic sermons; Wenzel *Macaronic Sermons* 101.
46. Indeed, the repentant Mankind does not use Latin, probably because he is no longer in a position to make any claim of authority.
47. 2 Corinthians 6: 2; Eccles *Macro Plays* at 227 note M 866.
48. Tim William Machan ‘Language Contact in *Piers Plowman*’ *Speculum* 69 (1994) 359–85 at 375. Although Langland was, of course, writing at a very different time it is nevertheless plausible that an author who could appreciate stylized, Latinate diction, as I argue the author of *Mankind* did, would similarly appreciate the stylistic effect of code switching between Latin and English.
49. See, for instance, Lawrence M. Clopper ‘*Mankind* and Its Audience’ in *Drama in the Middle Ages: Comparative and Critical Essays* edited Clifford Davidson and John H. Stroupe (Second Series; New York: AMS Press, 1991) 240–248 and Tom Pettitt ‘*Mankind*: An English *Fastnachtspiel*?’ in *Festive Drama: Papers from the Sixth Triennial Colloquium of the International Society for the Study of Medieval Theatre, Lancaster, 13–19 July, 1989* edited Meg Twycross (Cambridge: Brewer 1996) 190–202, especially 190–191.
50. Clopper ‘*Mankind* and Its Audience’ 243. See also Pettitt ‘*Mankind*: An English *Fastnachtspiel*?’ 191. Matthew Cheung-Salisbury, an expert of medieval liturgy,

is similarly of the opinion that the choice of biblical and liturgical extracts in the play indicates an educated, Latin-literate audience (private communication).

51. See, for example, Clopper 'Mankind and Its Audience' 240–248 at 245.
52. Dillon *Language and Stage* 61.
53. For the legal formula, see Jessica Brantley and Thomas Fulton 'Mankind in a Year without Kings' *Journal for Medieval and Early Modern Studies* 32 (2006) 321–54 at 328–2.
54. For the political context, see Brantley and Fulton, 'Mankind in a Year without Kings'. It is also worth pointing out that, according to the MED, *nullateni* is only attested in *Mankind* and that its associate noun *nullatense* (-ensis) is only attested in Lydgate. This is definitely too weak a link to prove a Lydgatean influence on the author of *Mankind* but it is intriguing nevertheless.
55. This does not preclude the presence of non-Latinate spectators at actual performance(s), of course.
56. Clopper points out that 'The presence of scatological humor, furthermore, need create no impediment against assigning the play to a literate or even aristocratic audience. Our tendency is to idealize the aristocracy and intelligentsia and its tastes' and cites John Heywood as another playwright who uses 'scurrilous' humor; Clopper 'Mankind and its Audience' 246. Note also that the monk Hyngham who owned the Macro manuscript would appear to have liked the scurrilous *Mankind* as well as the more serious *Wisdom*.
57. John Marshall "O 3e souerens þat sytt and 3e brothern þat stonde ryght wppe": Addressing the Audience in *Mankind* *European Medieval Drama* 1 (1997) 189–202 at 191–2.
58. There was some kind of dramatic activity on-going at Cambridge colleges at the time of *Mankind*'s probable date of composition (between 1465 and 1470) and a play could either have reached a Cambridge college as part of a travelling troupe's repertoire or have originated within the college; REED: *Cambridge* edited Alan H. Nelson, 2 vols. (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1989) 1 710–11. Moreover, an institution like King's College, which had been founded by Henry VI, would naturally feel some anti-Edwardian sentiment as expressed in the play. It is also worth pointing out that the age of new undergraduates was lower in the fifteenth century than nowadays, e.g. late-fourteenth-century statutes from Cambridge determine not to admit students under 14 years of age; Alan B. Cobban *English University Life in the Middle Ages* (London: UCL Press, 1999) 14, 20. Incidentally, it also appears that Cambridge colleges heavily recruited students from Norfolk, which could account for the references to places and people in Norfolk in a Cambridge university play; Cobban *English University Life* 16, 44. Our knowledge of dramatic performances at schools is even less

substantial, but it is not impossible that plays were put on. Notwithstanding some tantalising links, the situation is much the same for religious institutions in the fifteenth century. Thus, for example, whereas there was regular dramatic activity at the Cluniac Priory of St Mary at Thetford from 1498/9 onwards, no earlier record is found in the accounts which commence in 1483; Richard Beadle 'Plays and Playing at Thetford and Nearby 1498–1540' *Theatre Notebook* 32 (1978) 4–11. And despite the obvious Bury St Edmunds connection of the Macro manuscript and Lydgate's evident interest in dramatic spectacle, we have no hard evidence to prove that dramatic plays were put on at the monastery; Gibson, *Theater of Devotion* 112–14, 124.

59. It also indicates an all-male cast, but that in itself is not remarkable. Of course, the absence of mention of women in the play does not prove that there were no women in the audience.
60. Nicholas Orme *English Schools in the Middle Ages* (London: Methuen, 1973) 62–3. One is reminded of the schoolboys and their limited knowledge of the content of *Alma redemptoris* in 'The Prioress's Tale': 'I kan namoore expounde in this mateere. | I lerne song; I kan but smal grammeere.' (535–36); *The Riverside Chaucer* edited Larry D. Benson (Oxford UP, 3rd edition 1988) based on *The Works of Geoffrey Chaucer* edited F.N. Robinson (1957).
61. This need not indicate that those who used such texts in their devotions necessarily understood the Latin, of course.
62. Orme *English Schools* 70, 77; Shulamith Shahar *Childhood in the Middle Ages* translated Chaya Galai (London: Routledge, 1990) 187; and Cobban *English University Life* 4–5.
63. Marshall "O 3e souerens bat sytt", Orme *English Schools* 65.
64. There is perhaps an attempt to represent Mercy as a teacher, as rods were characteristic props for teachers and Mercy scares the Vices with 'a bales [switch]' (807), but Mercy's role as school-teacher is certainly not developed. He is addressed twice by Mankind as 'father' (209) and 'fader' (899), which makes it likely that he was represented as a member of the clergy; *Mankind: An Acting Edition* edited Peter Meredith (Leeds: Alumnus, 1997) 16 and Pamela M. King 'Morality plays' in *The Cambridge Companion to Medieval English Theatre* edited Richard Beadle and Alan J. Fletcher (Cambridge UP, 2nd edition 2008) 235–62 at 243.
65. It is also worth pointing out that the few stage directions are also in Latin, e.g. *Clamant* ('they cry') at 424, and *Loquitur ad* ('[he] speaks to') at 478 and 486 which also indicates that at least the person who put in these directions did not object to the use of Latin and imagined that these Latin stage directions would be comprehensible to the users of the text. Similarly, it is likely that Mankind recited the Paternoster until nature called, but only the first line is given in the

recorded text (554), which indicates that the author and/or scribe presumed the users of the text could supply the remnant of the prayer.

66. Dillon *Language and Stage* 67.
67. Dillon *Language and Stage* 67.
68. Gibson *Theater of Devotion* 34–8; but for a rejection of that reading see Michael Mark Chemers ‘Anti-Semitism, Surrogacy, and the Invocation of Mohammed in the *Play of the Sacrament*’ *Comparative Drama* 41:1 (2007) 25–55 at 34–5. However, the conviction that few Lollards would have been converted ‘by a rather silly and grotesque piece of stage business’ (35), especially as they abhorred dramatic representations, is not a strong argument against connecting the play with anti-Lollard propaganda. The fact that the play was in all likelihood primarily aimed at orthodox believers with an ‘affirmative’ (35) intent does not in itself undermine its anti-Lollard stance or its propaganda value (for non-Lollards).
69. Hudson *The Premature Reformation* 322–3. This connection is also highlighted in Dillon who, based on Gash, points out that one of the men in the 1457 East Anglian heresy trial was accused of this very belief; *Language and Stage* 57.